

AFP

> **"WAKER-UZ-ZAMAN IS A UNIQUE CASE. HE'S NOT TRYING TO STAGE A COUP. RATHER, HE WANTS FAIR ELECTIONS, WHICH IS THE DEMAND OF MOST BANGLADESHIS. SOUTH ASIA HAS NEVER SEEN SUCH A CASE"**
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> **ALTAF PARVEZ,** *Political researcher and historian*

leaders argue the reform is hasty and punitive, while civil servants see it as an attempt to impose top-down control without consultation.

## BNP–NCP Friction

While both BNP and the student activists played a key role in the July uprising, things have now soured between the two. The NCP's primary target has been BNP veteran and former minister Salahuddin Ahmed for his "rigid" stand; he is even accused of being an "Indian agent". BNP insiders say the rebel student leaders had reached out to Tarique Rahman, party chief Khaleda Zia's son and the party's acting chairperson, last year before they floated the NCP. "They admitted we were the most powerful political force and requested us to give up some seats for them," says a source. "Our chairperson asked them to speak to Mr Ahmed. But when he asked which seats they wanted, they named 12 but wanted nearly 100."

Tensions escalated further over the appointment of BNP leader Ishraque Hossain as mayor of Dhaka South City Corporation. The interim government has resisted the move with a petition in court arguing that all polls held under the previous Hasina regime should be declared invalid. The standoff has now literally put the corporation in limbo, with BNP protesters locking the gates of the Nagar Bhaban office. Meanwhile, on the other side, government advisor Bhuyian has greenlit the appointment of environmentalist Mohammad Azaz—who is alleged to have past links with the banned extremist outfit Hizb ut-Tahrir—for the Dhaka North City Corporation, prompting fresh alarm.

Beyond elections, Gen. Zaman has also taken a firm stand against several contentious policies floated by the interim administration. These include the proposed privatisation of the Chattogram Port and plans to establish an aid corridor to the conflict-hit Rakhine region of Myanmar. At the durbar, the army chief reportedly said, "Corridor, ports and other policy-related decisions